



DUNNE'S METHODOLOGY HAD DELIVERED STRIKING RESULTS IN IRELAND AND GREAT BRITAIN

Failed resistance: Amit Panghal (above right) and Arundhati Choudhary (far right) approached the courts for intervention, but the federation continued to back Dunne.

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to recover in time for the tournament that mattered. Dunne instead wanted to pick players based on consistency in training, discipline and sparring.

While it was a decision that was sound in principle, players were often left confused about where they stood in terms of selection. Two players — Amit Panghal (men's 51kg) and Arundhati Choudhary (women's 66kg) — would approach the courts for intervention, but despite that, the federation continued to back Dunne.

However, one of the consequences of Dunne's insistence on eliminating trials was that the buck, in terms of selection, ultimately stopped with him. The decision to pick World bronze medallist Deepak Bhorla in place of the reigning champion Amit for the Asian Games [which was the first Olympic qualification tournament] immediately backfired when he lost before the medal rounds.

Amit's exclusion from the Olympic qualifiers in Italy took on an even worse look considering he had just

won the prestigious Strandja Memorial Tournament just a few weeks before. Arundhati, who also reached the final of the Strandja tournament, beat France's Emilie Sonvico en route. The same opponent beat Ankushita Boro — who was picked for the qualifiers in place of Arundhati — in the first round.

"It's not just a matter of not picking one boxer. When you insist on sticking with just one boxer, apart from bringing down the confidence of the others, you are making the one who is selected overconfident. That's why we have trials," a coach says.

India no exception?

But for all the criticism of Dunne, there is another line of reasoning: that the decision to accept the Irishman's resignation was made in haste. All boxing programmes need time to settle down.

The methodology Dunne employs has delivered striking results in Ireland and Great Britain. And India under Dunne did pick up its best-ever result at the World Championships — winning three medals in the 2023 edition in Tashkent exactly a year ago.

Indian women's boxing hasn't done too badly either — they picked up four quotas from the Hangzhou Asian Games during Dunne's tenure.

A closer look at the immediate trigger for Dunne's exit is also not as clear-cut as it might seem. All but one (Lakshya Chahar in men's 80kg division) of the Indian men's boxers who were defeated at the Olympic qualifiers lost to the eventual quota winner.

The absence of video footage for any of the early matches also makes it uncertain whether an Indian boxer received a harsh decision. While India might not have won a single quota at the first Olympic qualifier, it's unlikely to be the same case in the second one at the end of May, regardless of whether Dunne's principles are junked or not.

With the world's top boxers having already booked their tickets to Paris either at the Continental Games or the first Olympic qualifier, the field in Bangkok will be a lot easier to navigate.

To add to the diminished field, there are as many quotas as there were in Italy, or in the case of the men's 57kg and 63.5kg categories, an extra one.

In the absence of Dunne, India's boxers and coaches will have to find their own paths. While they might be left in a state of confusion, coaches believe it is still possible to salvage the situation.